

Blood-Burning Moon

Jean Toomer · 1923

First published: Cane, 1923

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Cane_(Toomer)/Blood-Burning_Moon (revision 15075428), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Blood-Burning Moon suggest about racial violence in the South?
- What does Blood-Burning Moon suggest about love and rivalry?
- What does Blood-Burning Moon suggest about folk song and omen?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* Blood-Burning Moon	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*racial violence in the South* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to Blood-Burning Moon

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Jean Toomer's life or times connects to racial violence in the South in “Blood-Burning Moon”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (racial violence in the South, love and rivalry, folk song and omen).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Jean Toomer was born Nathan Pinchback Toomer in Washington, D.C., on 26 December 1894, the grandson of P. B. S. Pinchback, a Reconstruction-era governor of Louisiana. In 1921 he spent two months as a substitute school principal in Sparta, Georgia, an experience that inspired Cane (1923), a mixture of stories, poems and drama that became a landmark of the Harlem Renaissance. He later resisted being classified by race, became a follower of the mystic G. I. Gurdjieff and later a Quaker, and died on 30 March 1967.

Historical and cultural context

Set in a Georgia mill town in the early 1920s, the story reflects the Jim Crow South, where racial terror, including lynching, enforced segregation. Toomer wrote Cane after working as a substitute school principal in Sparta, Georgia, in 1921.

Publication and reception, then and now

Published in Cane (1923), a mix of stories, poems and drama; it had appeared earlier in the magazine Prairie (1923).

Then: Cane was praised by critics and fellow writers but sold poorly.

Now: Cane is a landmark of the Harlem Renaissance and modernism; this story is one of its most powerful sections.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Louisa, a young Black woman who works in a white family's kitchen, is loved by two men: Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a blood-red moon, the rivalry turns violent.

Main themes

- racial violence and injustice.
- love and possession.
- fate and omen.

Why it matters

The story confronts the history of lynching and its roots in the economics and sexual politics of the post-slavery South.

Spoilers · teacher only

Tom kills Bob in a knife fight; a white mob lynches Tom by burning him alive in the old factory, and Louisa, dazed, sings at her doorstep.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open Blood-Burning Moon: How can a song carry warning or grief?
Prompt: Before we open Blood-Burning Moon: How can a song carry warning or grief?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
modernism; refrain; omen; Harlem Renaissance; lyrical prose.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Jean Toomer was born Nathan Pinchback Toomer in Washington, D.C., on 26 December 1894, the grandson of P. B. S. Pinchback, a Reconstruction-era governor of Louisiana. In 1921 he spent two months as a substitute school principal in Sparta, Georgia, an experience that inspired Cane (1923), a mixture of stories, poems and drama that became a landmark of the Harlem Renaissance. He later resisted being classified by race, became a follower of the mystic G. I. Gurdjieff and later a Quaker, and died on 30 March 1967. The world of the book. Set in a Georgia mill town in the early 1920s, the story reflects the Jim Crow South, where racial terror, including lynching, enforced segregation. Toomer wrote Cane after working as a substitute school principal in Sparta, Georgia, in 1921. Publication and reception. Published in Cane (1923), a mix of stories, poems and drama; it had appeared earlier in the magazine Prairie (1923). Then: Cane was praised by critics and fellow writers but sold poorly. Now: Cane is a landmark of the Harlem Renaissance and modernism; this story is one of its most powerful sections.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory,..." slowly and put it in my own words: Dusk rises up out of the ruined walls and rotting floors of an old cotton factory from before the Civil War. Next, craft. I notice the sentence makes us wait through two "up from" phrases before its subject, "dusk," finally arrives. The strongest word is "pre-war": it ties the setting directly to slavery and the old South, so the past is literally the ground the story stands on. Then, effect. What does the slow build of this opening sentence do? My answer: Toomer roots the story in the ruins of slavery; the darkness rises out of that history, which predicts that the violence to come grows from it.

> *Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk came.* *(Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory,..." slowly and put it in my own words: Dusk rises up out of the ruined walls and rotting floors of an old cotton factory from before the Civil War. Next, craft. I notice the sentence makes us wait through two "up from" phrases before its subject, "dusk," finally arrives. The strongest word is "pre-war": it ties the setting directly to slavery and the old South, so the past is literally the ground the story stands on. Then, effect. What does the slow build of this opening sentence do? My answer: Toomer roots the story in the ruins of slavery; the darkness rises out of that history, which predicts that the violence to come grows from it.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Louisa, a young Black woman who works in a white family's kitchen, is loved by two men: Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a blood-red moon, the rivalry turns violent. Themes to track: racial violence and injustice.: love and possession.: fate and omen.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: love and rivalry. Prediction: Louisa's attachment to two men, Tom Burwell and Bob Stone, will be dangerous in a Georgia town divided by race. Question: what does the omen of the blood-red moon prepare me for?
Task: Set up a reading journal for Blood-Burning Moon: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: love and rivalry. Prediction: Louisa's attachment to two men, Tom Burwell and Bob Stone, will be dangerous in a Georgia town divided by race. Question: what does the omen of the blood-red moon prepare me for?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does Blood-Burning Moon still matter? The story confronts the history of lynching and its roots in the economics and sexual politics of the post-slavery South.
Anchor question: Why might Blood-Burning Moon still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story confronts the history of lynching and its roots in the economics and sexual politics of the post-slavery South.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Toomer wrote Cane (1923) after a few months teaching in rural Georgia, a trip that showed him the Southern Black life his family had left behind. How might an outsider's visit shape the book? Answer: Accept answers such as: he saw the beauty of Black folk songs and land and feared it was disappearing; he also saw lynching and racial violence; Cane mixes poetry and prose to capture a vanishing world.
Exit ticket: Toomer wrote Cane (1923) after a few months teaching in rural Georgia, a trip that showed him the Southern Black life his family had left behind. How might an outsider's visit shape the book?
Answer: Accept answers such as: he saw the beauty of Black folk songs and land and feared it was disappearing; he also saw lynching and racial violence; Cane mixes poetry and prose to capture a vanishing world.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: Blood-Burning Moon.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Jean Toomer" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Jean-Toomer); Poetry Foundation, "Jean Toomer" (https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/jean-toomer); Library of Congress, Jean Toomer and Cane (https://www.loc.gov/); Yale Beinecke Library, Jean Toomer Papers (https://beinecke.library.yale.edu/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Content note: lynching and racial slurs appear in the text, including in the song. Preview and plan carefully. The Prairie magazine prior publication should be checked against a scholarly edition of Cane.

Lesson 2: Blood-Burning Moon

Focus: love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

Objective: Students will analyze how imagery develops in "Blood-Burning Moon" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (graphic lynching, racial slurs, knife killing): Sensitive content: Graphic lynching; racial slurs; knife killing. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. The text quotes racial slurs in period dialogue: decide in advance that no one reads them aloud, and name why the author records them.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes graphic lynching; racial slurs; knife killing.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Louisa, a Black woman in a Georgia factory town, is loved by Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a full moon that the women read as an omen, Bob confronts Tom and is killed by Tom's knife. A white mob lynches Tom, burning him at the old factory. Louisa, unaware, sings to the moon.

Background: Published in Cane (1923), Toomer's experimental book of stories, poems and sketches rooted in rural Georgia; US copyright term has expired.

Significance: A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How can a song or image foreshadow danger? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to racial violence and injustice because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes graphic lynching; racial slurs; knife killing.
Prompt: How can a song or image foreshadow danger?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to racial violence and injustice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: canebrake — a thicket of tall cane plants; heralding — announcing that something is coming; jumbled — mixed up in a confused way; trickle — to flow in drops; cookery — the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat. "canebrake": Origin: an English formation from cane + brake. "jumbled": Origin of "jumble": uncertain; perhaps coined in the 1500s on the model of words like stumble and tumble. "trickle": Origin: probably Middle English triklen, a variant of striklen ("to flow gently"); the history is not certain. "cookery": Origin: an English formation from cook + -ery.
Words: canebrake: a thicket of tall cane plants · heralding: announcing that something is coming · jumbled: mixed up in a confused way · trickle: to flow in drops · cookery: the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in Cane (1923), Toomer's experimental book of stories, poems and sketches rooted in rural Georgia; US copyright term has expired. A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence. Refrain: The song ("Blood-burning moon. Sinner!") recurs, like a chorus. Imagery: Red, fire and blood saturate the story, from the moon to the burning factory. Structure: Three numbered parts in Cane (our reading text runs them together): Louisa and Tom Burwell's declaration; Bob Stone's jealous walk to the factory; the fight and the mob. Watch for the moon: omen of violence.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Blood-burning moon. Sinner" slowly and put it in my own words: The women of the factory town sing a refrain that names the red moon and calls out "Sinner." Next, craft. I notice the clipped, chant-like fragments, which sound like a spiritual or a warning rather than a sentence. The strongest word is "Sinner": it turns the song into a judgment, so the community seems to sense violence coming. Then, effect. Why do the women sing about a "blood-burning moon"? My answer: The red moon is an omen of the bloodshed to come; the refrain lets the community voice dread that no one says outright.

> *Blood-burning moon. Sinner* *(Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Blood-burning moon. Sinner" slowly and put it in my own words: The women of the factory town sing a refrain that names the red moon and calls out "Sinner." Next, craft. I notice the clipped, chant-like fragments, which sound like a spiritual or a warning rather than a sentence. The strongest word is "Sinner": it turns the song into a judgment, so the community seems to sense violence coming. Then, effect. Why do the women sing about a "blood-burning moon"? My answer: The red moon is an omen of the bloodshed to come; the refrain lets the community voice dread that no one says outright.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The "white folks' kitchen" shows Louisa's work for Bob's family, the root of the conflict. Ask: How does this line connect to racial violence and injustice? Expected: The mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. (Her divided world.)

> *Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The "white folks' kitchen" shows Louisa's work for Bob's family, the root of the conflict.
Ask: How does this line connect to racial violence and injustice?
Expected answer: The mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. (Her divided world.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for refrain, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Blood-Burning Moon develops the idea of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. When the text says “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55), it shows this directly. The song "Blood-burning moon. Sinner!" recurs as the conflict builds, so when "a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat," the reader feels the omen fulfilled.
Task: Annotate the story for refrain, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Blood-Burning Moon develops the idea of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. When the text says “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55), it shows this directly. The song "Blood-burning moon. Sinner!" recurs as the conflict builds, so when "a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat," the reader feels the omen fulfilled.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How can a song or image foreshadow danger? Handle with care: frame discussion around history and Toomer's craft.
Anchor question: How can a song or image foreshadow danger?
Facilitation: Handle with care: frame discussion around history and Toomer's craft.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. ("Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat", Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. ("Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat", Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how refrain shapes love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Key takeaway: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Refrain:** The song ("Blood-burning moon. Sinner!") recurs, like a chorus.
- **Imagery:** Red, fire and blood saturate the story, from the moon to the burning factory.
- **Structure:** Three numbered parts in Cane (our reading text runs them together): Louisa and Tom Burwell's declaration; Bob Stone's jealous walk to the factory; the fight and the mob.

Themes and how they develop

- **racial violence and injustice:** the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged.

Symbols and motifs

- **the moon:** omen of violence.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Blood-burning moon. Sinner" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5) The omen.
- "Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2) Her divided world.
- "Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55) The violence.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal.
Evidence: "Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55)
Reasoning: The song "Blood-burning moon. Sinner!" recurs as the conflict builds, so when "a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat," the reader feels the omen fulfilled.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
canebrake (noun)	a thicket of tall cane plants	*To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.*	"canebrake": Origin: an English formation from cane + brake. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/canebrake#Etymology)
heralding (verb)	announcing that something is coming	*Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.*	
jumbled (verb)	mixed up in a confused way	*But for some reason, they jumbled when her eyes gazed vacantly at the rising moon.*	"jumbled": Origin of "jumble": uncertain; perhaps coined in the 1500s on the model of words like stumble and tumble. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/jumble#Etymology)
trickle (verb)	to flow in drops	*Nails scratches let little lines of blood trickle down and mat into the hair.*	"trickle": Origin: probably Middle English triklen, a variant of striklen ("to flow gently"); the history is not certain. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/trickle#Etymology)
cookery (noun)	the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat	*He passed the house with its huge open hearth which, in the days of slavery, was the plantation cookery.*	"cookery": Origin: an English formation from cook + -ery. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/cookery#Etymology)
embarrassed (verb)	cause to be embarrassed; cause to feel self-conscious	*Then, with their eyes still upon him, he began to feel embarrassed.*	
ambling (verb)	walking at a slow, easy pace	*He went towards her, ambling, touched the brim of a marvelously shaped, spotted, felt hat, said he wanted to say something to her, and then found that he didnt know what*	

		he had to say, or if he did, that he couldnt say it.	

Discussion questions

1. How can a song or image foreshadow danger?
2. Where does imagery appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with racial violence in the South?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What do the women read the full moon as? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: An omen
2. Who are Louisa's two suitors? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Tom Burwell and Bob Stone
3. What building dominates the setting? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: An old pre-war cotton factory
4. How does Bob Stone die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Tom cuts his throat in a fight
5. What does Louisa do at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Sings to the moon, unaware
6. Retell the three most important events of “Blood-Burning Moon” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Louisa, a Black woman in a Georgia factory town, is loved by Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a full moon that the women read as an omen, Bob confronts Tom and is killed by Tom's knife. A white mob lynches Tom, burning him at the old factory. Louisa, unaware, sings to the moon.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “Blood-Burning Moon”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “Blood-Burning Moon” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.” What does “canebrake” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: canebrake: a thicket of tall cane plants.
10. Reread: “Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.” What does “heralding” mean here, and what is literally happening in

this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: heralding: announcing that something is coming.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Blood-Burning Moon” suggest about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence.
2. Find one example of imagery in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5): The omen. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk came.”, why might Toomer have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Blood-Burning Moon”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Louisa, a Black woman in a Georgia factory town, is loved by Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a full moon that the women read as an omen, Bob confronts Tom and is killed by Tom's knife. A white mob lynches Tom, burning him at the old…
6. As the opening story, what does “Blood-Burning Moon” set up that the rest of Blood-Burning Moon will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2): Her divided world. On structure: Three numbered parts in Cane (our reading text runs them together): Louisa and Tom Burwell's declaration; Bob Stone's jealous walk to the factory; the fight and the mob. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55): The violence. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. The bell-ringer asked: “How can a song or image foreshadow danger?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does foreshadowing appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with racial violence in the South? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5): The omen. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in Cane (1923), Toomer's experimental book of stories, poems and sketches rooted in rural Georgia; US copyright term has expired. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2): Her divided world. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55): The violence. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5): The omen. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “Blood-Burning Moon” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2): Her divided world. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while

Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “Blood-Burning Moon”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55): The violence. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to love and rivalry: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Toomer need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5): The omen. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the imagery in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2): Her divided world. On imagery: Red, fire and blood saturate the story, from the moon to the burning factory. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “Blood-Burning Moon” treats love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Blood-Burning Moon see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55): The violence. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve racial violence in the South? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5): The omen. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2): Her divided world. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Jean Toomer about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55): The violence. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Imagery:** look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Louisa do at the end?

   A. Flees

   B. Joins the mob

   C. Calls for help

   D. Sings to the moon, unaware

   Key: D (Sings to the moon, unaware)

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 24: “Figures shifted, _____-like, between lamp and window in the front rooms of the shanties.” Word bank: factory, restless, cleared, carried

   Key: restless

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 17: “But words is like th spots on dice: no matter how y _____ em, there's times when they jes wont come.” Word bank: nowadays, skeleton, thickness, fumbles

   Key: fumbles

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Then, with their eyes still upon him, he began to feel _____.” Word bank: heralding, jumbled, canebrake, embarrassed

   Key: embarrassed

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 10? “Beneath a swaying oil lamp, a Negro _____ whipped out at the mule, and fed cane-stalks to the grinder.”

   A. alternately

   B. thickness

C. fumbles

D. factory

Key: A (alternately)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 1: “Up from the _____ stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk came.” Word bank: nowadays, restless, skeleton, alternately

   Key: skeleton

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Who are Louisa's two suitors?

   A. Bob and Jim

   B. Tom Burwell and Bob Stone

   C. Tom and Sam

   D. Two brothers

   Key: B (Tom Burwell and Bob Stone)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He passed the house with its huge open hearth which, in the days of slavery, was the plantation _____.” Word bank: heralding, jumbled, canebrake, cookery

   Key: cookery

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How does Bob Stone die?

   A. Tom cuts his throat in a fight

   B. He is shot

   C. He falls

   D. He drowns

   Key: A (Tom cuts his throat in a fight)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 19? “An then besides, white folks aint up t them tricks so much _____.”

    A. carried

    B. nowadays

    C. thickness

    D. squatted

    Key: B (nowadays)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The omen. The evidence is “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5). This develops racial violence and injustice: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 23 reveal about the character or situation? “Sing, honey Louisa, an while I'm listenin t y I'll be makin love.’” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 23) shows the situation turning on love and rivalry: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The words “listenin” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in the story?

    A. “Up from the deep dusk of a cleared spot on the edge of the forest a mellow glow arose and spread fan-wise into the low-hanging heavens.”

    B. “Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk…”

    C. “And all around the air was heavy with the scent of boiling cane.”

    D. “Glowing like a fired pine-knot, it illumined the great door and soft showered the Negro shanties aligned along the single street of factory…”

    Key: B (“Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk…”)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 24 shapes its tone: “The old woman lifted the well-lid, took hold the chain, and began drawing up the heavy bucket.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “drawing” and “lifted” (paragraph 24) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to love and rivalry: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 48 shapes its tone: “A few dark figures, drawn by the sound of scuffle, stood about them.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “scuffle” and “figures” (paragraph 48) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to love and rivalry: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 10 to the story's treatment of love and rivalry: “Some of them chewed at the white pulp of stalks, but there was no need for them to, if all they wanted was to taste the cane.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 10) develops love and rivalry: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Its words “stalks” and “chewed” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “An here I is, but that aint ahelpin none, all th same.” (paragraph 15), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating love and rivalry as central.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2: “Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' _____”

    Key: kitchen

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What do the women read the full moon as?

    A. Nothing

    B. A sign of rain

    C. An omen

    D. A blessing

    Key: C (An omen)

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55: “Blue flash, a steel blade _____ across Bob Stone's throat”

    Key: slashed

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What building dominates the setting?

    A. A school

    B. An old pre-war cotton factory

    C. A church

    D. A courthouse

    Key: B (An old pre-war cotton factory)

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 10 shapes its tone: “A fat boy waddled pails of fresh ground juice between the grinder and the boiling stove.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “between” and “waddled” (paragraph 10) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to love and rivalry: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The omen. The evidence is “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5). This develops racial violence and injustice: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The words “burning” and “moon” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. The song "Blood-burning moon. Sinner!" recurs as the conflict builds, so when "a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat," the reader feels the omen fulfilled.

23. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He went towards her, _____, touched the brim of a marvelously shaped, spotted, felt hat, said he wanted to say something to her, and then found that he didnt know what he had to say, or if he did, that he couldnt say it.” Word bank: jumbled, heralding, ambling, canebrake

    Key: ambling

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 17 to the story's treatment of love and rivalry: “Lil gal, Ise watched y from them first days when youall sat right here befo yo door befo th well an sang sometimes in a way that like t broke m heart.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 17) develops love and rivalry: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Its words “sometimes” and “watched” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Seems like th love I feels fo yo done stole m tongue.” (paragraph 17), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating love and rivalry as central.

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how racial violence and injustice develops from the opening of “Blood-Burning Moon” to its ending. Use one quotation from each part.

    Sample answer: Near the start, “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5) — The omen. Later, “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55) — The violence. The mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged.

26. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Claim: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55).

    Sample answer: The song "Blood-burning moon. Sinner!" recurs as the conflict builds, so when "a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat," the reader feels the omen fulfilled. The evidence is “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's

throat" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55) — The violence. This develops racial violence and injustice: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged.

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line "Nails scratches let little lines of blood trickle down and mat into the hair.", what does "trickle" most nearly mean?

    A. to flow in drops

    B. announcing that something is coming

    C. mixed up in a confused way

    D. a thicket of tall cane plants

    Key: A (to flow in drops)

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze the word choice in "Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The violence. The evidence is "Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55). This develops racial violence and injustice: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The words "slashed" and "throat" carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

29. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.5] Which literary element does this describe in "Blood-Burning Moon"? The song ('Blood-burning moon. Sinner!') recurs, like a chorus.

    A. Refrain

    B. Foreshadowing

    C. Personification

    D. Metaphor

    Key: A (Refrain)

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Her divided world. The evidence is "Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2). This develops racial violence and injustice: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The words "kitchen" and "folks'" carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. The song "Blood-burning moon. Sinner!" recurs as the conflict builds, so when "a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat," the reader feels the omen fulfilled.

31. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] In the line "But for some reason, they jumbled when her eyes gazed vacantly at the rising moon.", what does "jumbled" most nearly mean?

    A. to flow in drops

    B. announcing that something is coming

    C. a thicket of tall cane plants

    D. mixed up in a confused way

    Key: D (mixed up in a confused way)

32. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] In the line "Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.", what does "heralding" most nearly mean?

    A. announcing that something is coming

    B. mixed up in a confused way

    C. a thicket of tall cane plants

    D. to flow in drops

    Key: A (announcing that something is coming)

33. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in "Blood-Burning Moon"? Red, fire and blood saturate the story, from the moon to the burning factory.

    A. Characterization

    B. Point of view

    C. Imagery

    D. Alliteration

    Key: C (Imagery)

34. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C4-LIT-1] In the line "To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.", what does "canebrake" most nearly mean?

    A. mixed up in a confused way

    B. a thicket of tall cane plants

    C. to flow in drops

    D. announcing that something is coming

    Key: B (a thicket of tall cane plants)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 5, 17, 18, 19, 8, 2, 4, 20, 7, 13, 12, 15, 21, 14, 22	recall 10, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	9, 5, 23, 7, 8, 4, 3, 18, 1, 12, 13, 14, 21, 15, 24, 25	recall 9, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	19, 1, 5, 7, 18, 6, 17, 9, 23, 12, 13, 21, 14, 15, 22, 24	recall 9, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Senior	2, 8, 3, 1, 17, 5, 20, 13, 12, 14, 26, 21, 15, 16, 24, 25	recall 7, inference 2, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	18, 20, 3, 27, 23, 7, 12, 13, 21, 28, 14, 29, 15, 24, 30, 16	recall 6, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 3
College Freshman	20, 3, 8, 10, 31, 1, 27, 12, 13, 26, 15, 14, 21, 24, 16, 25	recall 7, inference 2, analysis 4, synthesis 3
College Sophomore	8, 10, 2, 1, 17, 23, 31, 13, 11, 12, 14, 21, 15, 26, 16, 24	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
College Junior	23, 4, 27, 8, 6, 32, 13, 12, 28, 21, 33, 14, 15, 24, 16, 30	recall 6, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 3
College Senior	23, 32, 8, 27, 1, 34, 3, 12, 13, 14, 21, 15, 30, 16, 22, 24	recall 7, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	2, 32, 27, 7, 34, 23, 12, 13, 14, 26, 21, 15, 22, 24, 16, 30	recall 6, inference 2, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Blood-Burning Moon,” how does Toomer show love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the imagery you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): In Blood-Burning Moon, how does Toomer develop the idea of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the imagery in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Blood-Burning Moon develops the idea of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (where it begins, turns and ends) and its imagery shape the reader's understanding of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what Blood-Burning Moon suggests about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's imagery and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Jean Toomer uses imagery in Blood-Burning Moon to complicate the reader's understanding of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Blood-Burning Moon within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Blood-Burning Moon alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence follows or bends those conventions, using the imagery as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Blood-Burning Moon and its treatment of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's imagery and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Blood-Burning Moon as evidence for a larger claim about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence in Blood-Burning Moon. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Blood-Burning Moon as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Blood-Burning Moon.

SAT-style questions

1. *But for some reason, they jumbled when her eyes gazed vacantly at the rising moon.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "jumbled" most nearly mean?

   A. cause to be embarrassed; cause to feel self-conscious

   B. walking at a slow, easy pace

   C. the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat

   D. mixed up in a confused way

2. *Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk came. Up from the dusk the full moon came. Glowing like a fired pine-knot, it illumined the great door and soft showered the Negro shanties aligned along the single street of factory town. The full moon in the great door was an omen. Negro women improvised songs against its spell.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Blood-Burning Moon"?

   A. The art of the deadpan tall tale

   B. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

   C. Revenge carried out with perfect control

   D. A choice the reader must make

SAT key: 1. D (mixed up in a confused way); 2. B (Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence)

Unit test

Blood-Burning Moon: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 17: “Ise _____ y with me into th fields, day after day, an after that, an I sho can plow when yo is there, an I can pick cotton.” Word bank: holding, thickness, carried, skeleton
   Key: carried
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 10? “And from _____ town one could see the soft haze thrown by the glowing stove upon the low-hanging heavens.”
   A. carried
   B. factory
   C. thickness
   D. squatted
   Key: B (factory)
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 17? “Louisa, honey, I _____ tell y, I feel I oughtnt cause yo is young an goes t church an I has had other gals, but Louisa I sho do love y.”
   A. oughtnt
   B. carried
   C. squatted
   D. meeting
   Key: A (oughtnt)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 10: “A large pile of cane-stalks lay like _____ shadows upon the ground.” Word bank: carried, thickness, oughtnt, ribboned
   Key: ribboned
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 24? “An old woman brought a lighted lamp and hung it on the common well whose bulky shadow _____ in the middle of the road, opposite Tom and Louisa.”
   A. squatted
   B. holding

C. factory

D. carried

Key: A (squatted)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 41: “He got to his feet and walked calmly to their _____ place.” Word bank: squatted, thickness, meeting, factory

   Key: meeting

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 41? “Bob Stone's ears burned as though he had been _____ them over the stove.”

   A. fragrance

   B. meeting

   C. holding

   D. nowadays

   Key: C (holding)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 24: “Against the tough _____ of his own, hers felt soft and small.” Word bank: thickness, fragrance, factory, skeleton

   Key: thickness

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 10? “Up from the deep dusk of a _____ spot on the edge of the forest a mellow glow arose and spread fan-wise into the low-hanging heavens.”

   A. fragrance

   B. cleared

   C. factory

   D. skeleton

   Key: B (cleared)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 10: “The scent of cane came from the copper pan and drenched the forest and the hill that sloped to factory town, beneath its _____.” Word bank: fragrance, nowadays, ribboned, thickness

    Key: fragrance

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 41 reveal about the character or situation? “Palpitant between the rooster crows, a chill hush settled upon the huddled forms of Tom and Louisa.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 41) shows the situation turning on racial violence in the South: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The words “between” and “huddled” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 1 reveal about the character or situation? “Glowing like a fired pine-knot, it illumined the great door and soft showered the Negro shanties aligned along the single street of factory town.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 1) shows the situation turning on racial violence in the South: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The words “illumined” and “shanties” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 15 reveal about the character or situation? “An here I is, but that aint ahelpin none, all th same.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 15) shows the situation turning on folk song and omen: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The words “ahelpin” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 24 shapes its tone: “Shadows of the figures fought each other on the gray dust of the road.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “figures” and “fought” (paragraph 24) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to folk song and omen: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 17 shapes its tone: “Seems like th love I feels fo yo done stole m tongue.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “tongue” (paragraph 17) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to folk song and omen: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 17 shapes its tone: “An next year if ole Stone'll trust me, I'll have a farm.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words its wording (paragraph 17) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to racial violence in the South: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 10 shapes its tone: “And all around the air was heavy with the scent of boiling cane.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “boiling” and “around” (paragraph 10) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to racial violence in the South: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 10 to the story's treatment of folk song and omen: “A mule, harnessed to a pole, trudged lazily round and round the pivot of the grinder.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 10) develops folk song and omen: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Its words “harnessed” and “trudged” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “And all around the air was heavy with the scent of boiling cane.” (paragraph 10), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating folk song and omen as central.

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 41 to the story's treatment of folk song and omen: “After a long while, or so it seemed to him, the thought came to him that it must be time to see Louisa.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 41) develops folk song and omen: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Its words “thought” and “seemed” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Palpitant

between the rooster crows, a chill hush settled upon the huddled forms of Tom and Louisa." (paragraph 41), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating folk song and omen as central.

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 58 shapes its tone: "Then nothing could be heard but the flop of their feet in the thick dust of the road." Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words "nothing" (paragraph 58) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to racial violence in the South: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 17 to the story's treatment of racial violence in the South: "Silk stockings an purple dresses—course I dont believe what some folks been whisperin as t how y gets them things now." Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 17) develops racial violence in the South: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Its words "whisperin" and "stockings" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "Sing, honey Louisa, an while I'm listenin t y I'll be makin love.'" (paragraph 23), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating racial violence in the South as central.
22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 24 to the story's treatment of racial violence in the South: "The full moon sank upward into the deep purple of the cloud-bank." Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 24) develops racial violence in the South: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Its words "upward" and "purple" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "The old woman lifted the well-lid, took hold the chain, and began drawing up the heavy bucket." (paragraph 24), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating racial violence in the South as central.
23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 58 to the story's treatment of folk song and omen: "And then he saw the search-lights of the two cars glaring down on him." Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 58) develops folk song and omen: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Its words "glaring" and "lights" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "Then nothing could be heard but the flop of their feet in the thick dust of the road." (paragraph 58), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating folk song and omen as central.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	8, 10, 7, 2, 1, 3, 4, 9, 6, 5, 11, 12, 13, 15, 16, 17, 14, 19	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	6, 4, 3, 7, 1, 10, 2, 9, 5, 8, 11, 13, 12, 15, 20, 14, 21, 18	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	5, 2, 3, 1, 4, 7, 10, 8, 9, 12, 11, 13, 15, 20, 14, 16, 22, 19	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	4, 10, 5, 3, 1, 2, 9, 8, 12, 11, 13, 20, 16, 14, 17, 22, 18, 21	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP		

	6, 2, 8, 5, 3, 12, 13, 11, 20, 16, 17, 15, 14, 21, 19, 23, 18, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Freshman	4, 3, 7, 9, 1, 13, 11, 12, 20, 15, 17, 16, 14, 23, 22, 19, 18, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Sophomore	6, 1, 3, 8, 2, 13, 12, 11, 14, 17, 16, 15, 20, 18, 23, 19, 21, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	6, 10, 8, 2, 5, 13, 12, 11, 15, 20, 17, 16, 14, 21, 18, 19, 23, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	9, 8, 10, 7, 4, 12, 11, 13, 14, 15, 20, 17, 16, 22, 19, 18, 23, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	4, 2, 1, 10, 5, 12, 11, 13, 16, 15, 14, 17, 20, 21, 19, 18, 22, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Final paper

Blood-Burning Moon: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Jean Toomer develops racial violence in the South across Blood-Burning Moon. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in Blood-Burning Moon and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to love and rivalry.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in Blood-Burning Moon. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether Blood-Burning Moon finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of folk song and omen. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor	Exemplary	Proficient	Developing	Beginning
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.	Specific, arguable and precise; it organizes every section.	Clear and arguable, but broad in places.	States a topic or a summary more than an argument.	Missing, or restates the prompt.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.	Accurate, well-chosen quotations from across the work, all cited; meets the requirement.	Accurate and cited, but clustered in one part of the work.	Too few quotations, or some inaccurate or uncited.	Little or no quoted evidence.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.	Explains how specific words, structure and devices create meaning; weighs a competing reading.	Explains the evidence, with some close reading.	Mostly summary; the link to the claim is asserted, not shown.	Summary only.

Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.	Each paragraph advances the argument; transitions show logic.	Logical order with minor jumps.	Order is loose; paragraphs repeat or drift.	No discernible structure.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.	Formal, precise, present tense; MLA format; virtually error-free.	Formal with a few errors that do not obscure meaning.	Informal or error-prone in ways that distract.	Errors obscure meaning.

Exemplar paragraph: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. The text makes this visible when it says “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55). The song "Blood-burning moon. Sinner!" recurs as the conflict builds, so when "a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat," the reader feels the omen fulfilled. A full paper would carry this reading through the beginning, middle and end, and answer the strongest competing reading.

Essay assignments

Essay: Racial violence in the South

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Blood-Burning Moon teaches about racial violence in the South. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jean Toomer develops racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jean Toomer develops racial violence in the South across Blood-Burning Moon. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of racial violence in the South. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jean Toomer's choices in Blood-Burning Moon (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of racial violence in the South, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Blood-Burning Moon's treatment of racial violence in the South in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Love and rivalry

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Blood-Burning Moon teaches about love and rivalry. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jean Toomer develops love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jean Toomer develops love and rivalry across Blood-Burning Moon. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of love and rivalry. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jean Toomer's choices in Blood-Burning Moon (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of love and rivalry, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Blood-Burning Moon's treatment of love and rivalry in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Folk song and omen

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Blood-Burning Moon teaches about folk song and omen. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jean Toomer develops folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jean Toomer develops folk song and omen across Blood-Burning Moon. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of folk song and omen. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jean Toomer's choices in Blood-Burning Moon (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of folk song and omen, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Blood-Burning Moon's treatment of folk song and omen in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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